



Focus stacking with Picolay

Get crystal clear macro shots and landscapes

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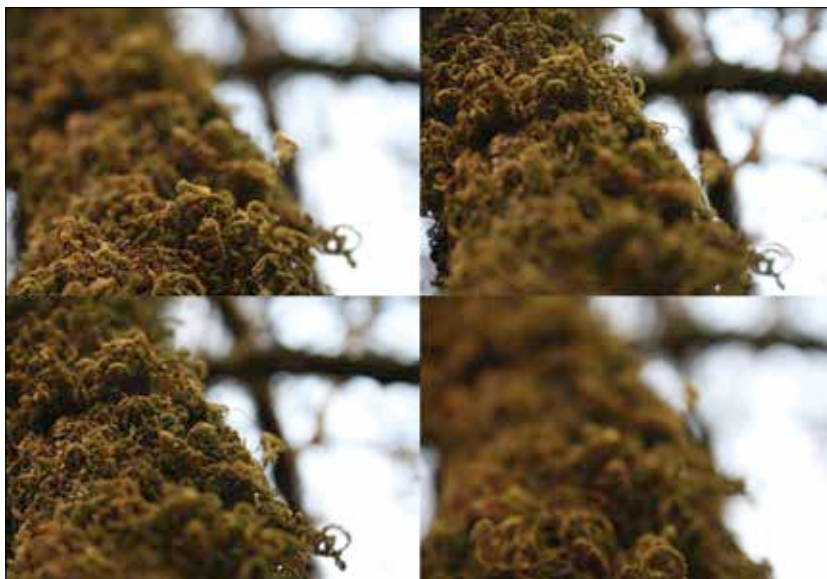
Focus stacking, like other stacking methods, involves taking multiple photos of the same subject, but only changing one setting in the camera. Then, these photos are brought together to produce an optimum image. The use of focus stacking is to make sure that everything in the image is crystal clear, even though the lens might not be a deep focus lens. This is a technique that works in landscape shots with foreground elements, as well as macro shots where lenses typically do not have the depth of field necessary to capture the entire subject in focus. One of the most useful places where focus stacking dramatically improves the image, is in low light conditions where a wider aperture is required. A wider aperture means a shallower depth of field, and fewer things in the frame will be in focus at any point of time. Boosting the ISO is only going to make the image

more noisy, so if you have the time, better to take the effort of capturing multiple images with different focus settings, allowing you to obtain a crystal clear image in the end.

STEP 1: CAPTURE THE IMAGES

More than the software part, this

is the step that is actually the most difficult. There are a few things you have to ensure while capturing images that have to be focus stacked later. The most important thing here is to use a tripod, and a dSLR. While it is possible to use a point and shoot or even a smartphone, the best results are obtained with a dSLR. Now it is important to make sure that the subjects are moving as little as possible, and this includes the movement introduced into the camera by the triggering of the shutter. If possible, use a clicker or remote, and if one is not available, then set the camera to use a timer, even a 10 or 5 second one is sufficient. Then, put the camera in manual focus, and shoot with either maximum focus, or minimum focus. After this, slowly move the focus ring and keep taking photos. The more photos you take, the better the final image will be. There is no need to go overboard, sometimes a good stack can be achieved in as few as four or six photos. The basic idea is to make sure that the series of images are captured in such a way, that everything in the image is in focus in at least one frame. With a point and shoot, it is essentially the same approach, just go to manual mode and change the focus in small increments. With a smartphone, the process involves tapping on different parts of the image to bring it into focus, generally, but this also changes the other settings in the device such



A stack of images with different points in focus